With Richard Nixon, the United States and China achieved the first step in their rapprochement and China was shaped into a strategic partner of the United States. If a capitalist power was being delineated in the Asian interior, at the same time China was transforming into a geopolitical barrier for the United States. It would be able to access the US market and concurrently the US bourgeoisie would have cheap, skilled and disciplined labour at its disposal. With Mao's successor, Deng Xiaoping, a new bourgeoisie appeared under the auspices of the Communist Party and with the advantageous opening of United States markets a reform began favouring exports. China became converted into the workshop of the world thanks to foreign investments. Its manufactured goods exports which were 50% in 1980 reached 95% in 2005 (Durand et al. 2008).

Nevertheless, Chinese development also signified a series of shocks for the workforce and nature. Industrialisation caused famines and destroyed a good part of traditional agriculture in order to be replaced by hydroelectric plants and reservoirs putting an end to many of the centuries-old productive systems. Parallel to this, the work days imposed on the labour force were extremely difficult; despite the control the state exercised over almost every sphere of life, social discontent set off a series of protests across the country in recent years. It would evoke a nightmare that has always weighed upon those in the bureaucracy and the dominant classes: the rebellion of the oppressed.

The immense Chinese population provides millions of labourers who work long hours and days in *maquiladora* plants at the lowest salaries in the world. Without a doubt this is what is behind the wave of strikes China has witnessed in the last few years. Worker strikes and suicides are provoking a wage reform. Remunerations have increased steeply in the last five years. According to the ILO (International Labour Organisation), the rise in salaries has no equal anywhere in the world. This upsurge has caused the economy to decelerate from an annual growth rate of 12% to around 8%. It is said that this rise has encouraged many firms to migrate to such countries as Vietnam or Bangladesh, according to the Chinese government; it will facilitate the creation of a domestic market and a better quality industry.

In spite of this wage increase, problems continue in the Chinese countryside from where it is hoped that tens of millions of peasants will relocate to the cities, in order to fuel the Industrial Reserve Army. The phenomenon can be understood as primitive accumulation. Nevertheless, the problems are also environmental: deforestation has accompanied Chinese capitalist development and the country lacks water because, in spite of the presence of the Himalayas, it does not have large reserves of fresh water. In addition to this, the Chinese